Meatloaf

By Derrick Brown

INTRODUCTION

Nearly one out of every two marriages ends in divorce these days. And though the divorce rate has leveled off recently, one million new children a year are living through the breakups of their families. When a father abandons his family, the break up is especially difficulty for the mothers and sons who are left to cope alone. Derrick Brown recalls in his poem "Meatloaf" a discussion he had with his mother regarding the meaning of love and commitment. Meatloaf by Derrick Brown.

My mother is washing the dishes and singing
a song about someone dancing on the moon.

She stops to pat the globe of her stomach.
"So full."

I help her with the dirty meatlof dishes and pass them
from the table
The gunk slides through the soap
and the green goo slips across her strong hands.

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There is a flash of light every time she turns
her palm through the soap.
My mother has a small diamond
that she received on her wedding day.

It was given to her by my father,
as a symbol.

It was very affordable.

I always asked her why a diamond meant
that you loved someone?

Why not a brick, snail, wombat, or cat brain?

Why not give someone a pair of handcuffs
to show the world that this person will be with you
forever?

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Why not a steamroller
and you can tell your love that your world is flat without
them?

Why not give them a trophy of a zombie to prove
that you will kiss their brains out?

There is diswashing liquid in a brigade of bulging bubbles
and the "tink spink" of moving plates, and my mother is
singing again.

To her, the diamond ring was a cheap, special reminder:
--my dad's bright trying eyes,
--a relationship of exhausting sacrifices,
-- a beauty once hidden in the earth, but revealed to the
hand of the searcher.

The garbage disposal does its horrible growl.

My mother says she loves the way
the diamond catches the light

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and shoots it into your eye like sitting across from
someone
who just bit into fresh grapefruit.

The filthy forks sifted through her hands as the
disposal burled:
"Gnrlwygnlrygnlrywy."

She stopped singing and turned off the disposal.
Her face turned the color of the kitchen sink walls.

Water off.
She tosses through the plates.
She pulls out a rubber doo-dad to check the garbage
disposal,
continues this for about ten minutes.

I wait for her to say it.
I can feel my face, ready to burst like a cloud.

"It's gone. I can't believe we were just talking about it

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and it's gone."
She patted my head and handed me a paper towel.

"It's okay, Mom. It's just a thing."

"Not really." She starts to weep a little. "Excuse me."

She goes to the bathroom to blow her nose,
returning, kissing my head and going back to washing the
dishes with me,
scanning every bubble's gleam for the rock.

I roll my damp paper towel into a ring and give it to her.
"If we weren't blood, I'd marry you. And I'd stick
around."
She replies, "That is sweet, Illegal, a little weird, but so
sweet, Derrick."
She grabs some tape so it would stay wrapped up.

I sneak outside to the neighbors' place
and steal her a brick

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from their garden.

When I come back in,
she smiles and begins to sing that song
of someone somewhere
dancing on the moon,
a song about a boy spinning in the dark
with a beam of light.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Derrick Brown
Book: Scandalabra: A Collection of Poetry and Prose
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AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier

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NOTE: Link to the artist's performance of this poem which includes the "song" he mentions

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UqZXXXQvMtA

Although it appears that the song in the video are original lyrics written by Derrick C. Brown – We are unable to verify the publication of these lyrics. (shown below)

You hold my face
and you hold my faith.
I'll catch you in space,
I'll catch you in stars.
For you, my love,
I'll hang in your chest.
I'm hearin' you best,
I'm hearin' you say,
You're here, whispering in my ear,
You're here, whispering in my ear.
[…]
I'm here, whispering in you ear,
I'm here, whispering in your ear.
Here, child, whispering in your ear.
I'm here.
I'm here.

This performance piece would be beautiful with lyrics from any related song, however. Use caution when adding in lyrics so you are not in violation of your state or national "rules" for poetry.

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